Milgram’s experiment

Hi everyone, welcome. This is the tenth episode of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:16] Yes, it’s already the tenth episode. It’s been a little over two months since I started this podcast, and I’m very happy because there are more and more listeners. Among these listeners is Brooke, who comes from Australia. Brooke left me a comment on iTunes a few days ago. So I’m going to tell you a little about this comment.

[00:00:50] Brooke studied French at school, but afterwards she didn’t practise for a long time. That’s a problem many people have: they learn a language at school, but afterwards they don’t necessarily have the time or the desire to keep learning. Fortunately, Brooke decided to refresh her French. And she found my podcast on iTunes. Generally, she listens to it several times and uses the transcript on my website to repeat. I think that’s a very good idea if you want to improve your pronunciation. You can read the transcript and repeat after me. That way, little by little, you learn to pronounce certain words better or make the right liaisons, the links between words. I know some of my students have problems with liaisons. They don’t know when to link words together. For that, in my opinion, the best way to learn is precisely to listen to native speakers and try to repeat after them. So thank you, Brooke, for this very good suggestion, and especially thank you for your comment.

[00:02:41] If you also like my podcast and want to help me, don’t hesitate to leave a comment on iTunes. It really helps me a lot and lets me reach even more listeners and help even more people learn French. And I also remind you that the transcripts of all my podcasts are available on my website, cottongue.com. If you want the transcripts, go and have a look at my website.

[00:03:21] I’ll also take this opportunity to tell you I created a Facebook page a few weeks ago, and on this page I share lots of things I find interesting, not only my podcasts. I also share videos and things I analyse, so you can do a little French every day, read, listen to or watch interesting things in French. Go and have a look at this page. I’m sure you’ll find interesting things. It’s the “Innerfrench” page on Facebook.

[00:04:17] I used the expression “jeter un coup d’œil”. Sometimes we also say “jeter un œil”. It’s a very useful expression meaning “to go and look at something quickly”, to have a look. For example, “jeter un œil sur un article” means reading this article, or simply reading its beginning, quickly, “having a look”. If you want to recommend something to a friend, you can say, “You should have a look at this article.” That means looking at the article quickly.

[00:05:07] For this tenth podcast, we’re going to talk about psychology. To do that, we’ll go back a little in time. We’ll return to the sixties, more precisely the early sixties.

[00:05:27] In the early sixties, an American professor at Yale University was about to carry out an experiment that would transform psychology. This professor was Stanley Milgram.

[00:05:46] You’re probably wondering how this professor, Stanley Milgram, revolutionised psychology. If you want to know, listen to the rest of this podcast, because today I’m talking about Milgram’s experiment.

[00:06:08] Are you ready? Then here we go!

[00:06:22] To begin, I'm going to tell you a little about Stanley Milgram's life. Stanley Milgram was born in 1933 in New York, into a family of Jewish immigrants. Stanley's parents, of Hungarian and Romanian origin, emigrated to the United States during the First World War. This is important to know because later, the Holocaust and the trial of Lieutenant Adolf Eichmann would greatly influence Milgram's experiments. But let's not go too fast. Let's first return to young Stanley Milgram's childhood. You should know his family didn't have much money. His father was a baker. He made bread. Stanley's family lived in a fairly poor neighbourhood of New York called the Bronx. At school, Stanley worked very hard and was a brilliant pupil. He obtained a bachelor's degree in political science at Queens College. Then he became interested in psychology and tried to join the Department of Social Relations at Harvard University. But his application was rejected because at that time he had never taken a psychology course. A little later, in 1954, after taking several courses, he finally managed to join the department at Harvard University. He began his doctorate. He finished this doctorate six years later, in 1960, and became an assistant in the Department of Social Relations. He also worked as an assistant to the famous social psychology professor Solomon Asch. Professor Asch's research would inspire Milgram's future experiments. Solomon Asch was interested in conformity. Conformity is adapting our behaviour to a rule or an authority. When we conform to a rule, we respect it completely. Through his experiments, Solomon Asch showed that individuals are sometimes victims of group pressure. You've probably already observed this phenomenon: when we're in a group, we tend to conform to what its members think, even if we disagree. We've all experienced this kind of situation, at school or during a meeting at work, for example. It's difficult to stand alone against everyone. When all the other group members oppose you and hold a different opinion, generally it's easier to conform, easier to follow the majority's opinion.

[00:10:27] In July 1961, Stanley Milgram began his own experiments, the ones that would make him world-famous, at Yale University.

[00:10:52] We are looking for people for a study of memory.

[00:10:57] We will pay you four dollars for one hour of your time.

[00:11:03] This study will be conducted at Yale University.

[00:11:08] The study will last about one hour. There are no other obligations.

[00:11:14] You can choose a time that suits you: weekdays, evenings or weekends. No training, education or experience required.

[00:11:28] Everyone must be between twenty and fifty years old.

[00:11:34] We do not accept high school or university students.

[00:11:38] If you would like to participate in the experiment and meet the criteria, complete the coupon below and send it to Professor Stanley Milgram, Department of Psychology, Yale University.

[00:12:06] With this small advertisement, published in a local New Haven newspaper, Stanley Milgram recruited participants for his experiment. At that time, payment of four dollars an hour was quite good, quite a good deal! You should know the average wage at that time was twenty-five dollars for a week. So four dollars an hour was a rather interesting offer.

[00:12:47] The people who decided to participate came from different backgrounds. There were office employees, manual workers, managers and so on. They really were people with different origins and different circumstances. These people were welcomed into a laboratory at Yale University. In the laboratory were Stanley Milgram and another professor assisting him. There was also a second person who would take part in the experiment at the same time.

[00:13:37] First, the principle of the experiment was explained to both participants. You remember the advertisement said this was an experiment to measure memory. More precisely, this experiment aimed to measure the impact of punishment on memory. Perhaps you've heard these stories, or perhaps experienced them, but several decades ago, schools thought punishment was a good way to make pupils learn. They thought that if pupils were afraid of being punished, they would be more motivated to learn. So this experiment tried to measure precisely the link between punishment and memory.

[00:14:49] In this experiment, there was a learner and a teacher. The learner's role was to memorise a list of word pairs. There were different associations between a noun and an adjective, for example blue sky, toasted bread, strong wind and so on. Each time there was a noun and an adjective, and a list of thirty associations the learner had to learn by heart. The teacher's role was to read this list once for the learner to learn it, then punish the learner for giving a wrong answer.

[00:15:48] You're probably wondering what the learner's punishment was. The punishment was a fifteen-volt electric shock. The learner sat on a chair, and for a wrong answer received a fifteen-volt electric shock. But that wasn't all: the intensity of these shocks gradually increased. The first electric shock was fifteen volts, but the second was thirty volts, then forty-five, sixty, seventy-five volts and so on and so on. With every wrong answer, the intensity of the electric shock increased.

[00:16:43] Naturally, you can imagine participants preferred playing the teacher. But participants couldn't decide their role, because this decision was actually made at random. There were two pieces of paper, and the participant drew one at random, chose one of the two pieces, which stated which role they would play: teacher or learner. Once the roles were assigned, the learner went into another room next to the teacher's room, and the two participants could no longer see each other. However, they could hear each other: the teacher heard the learner's answers, and the learner heard the teacher's questions. The teacher faced a machine with different buttons for sending electric shocks. Beside the teacher was Milgram's assistant, who supervised the experiment and told the teacher what to do if the teacher had questions.

[00:18:24] At the beginning of the experiment, things were fine. The shocks were fairly weak, so when the learner gave a wrong answer, the teacher didn't really hesitate to send a shock. But gradually the shocks became stronger and stronger. After a while, the learner asked to stop, saying he had heart problems and these electric shocks were very risky for him. Of

course, the participant playing the teacher began having doubts. Sometimes he asked Milgram's assistant whether he should continue, saying he could hear the learner asking to stop. So the teacher wondered whether to continue or stop. But the assistant replied that he had to continue, that it was necessary for the experiment. The experiment had to continue until the learner knew all the associations by heart, or until the maximum electric discharge. That maximum was 450 volts. You should know that from 230 volts, an electric discharge, an electric shock, can be fatal.

[00:20:14] We might think this experiment is cruel and stupid, right? Do you seriously think we learn better when we're afraid of punishment? Personally, I think the opposite: we learn better when we feel good and confident. So this experiment is stupid, isn't it? Why would such an experiment have become so famous?

[00:20:49] In fact, this is what's very interesting: memory wasn't what was being tested in this experiment. What was tested was submission to authority. Stanley Milgram wanted to see whether participants would accept the rules completely, whether they would submit to his authority and his assistant's. Fortunately, there were no real electric shocks. The second participant, playing the learner, was an actor. He was an accomplice of Milgram's team, part of the team. So the only participant being tested was the person playing the teacher. In reality, this person thought he was chosen at random, but his teacher role was assigned automatically. And of course, the learner received no electric shock. It was simply a recording. The teacher heard the learner's reactions and screams on a recording.

[00:22:25] Ultimately, the aim of this experiment was to see how far the participant would agree to go, to what intensity of electric shocks. Stanley Milgram wanted to see whether these people would submit completely to authority or, by contrast, decide to rebel, to revolt against it.

[00:22:56] How many people do you think went to the end of the experiment? How many administered the maximum shock of 450 volts? Well, in the first version of the experiment, 65% of people, meaning twenty-six out of forty, went to the end! Afterwards, Stanley Milgram carried out different versions of this experiment, and the results varied to different degrees, but they were always very high.

[00:23:50] The results of Milgram's experiment were very shocking to the scientific community. Nobody imagined such a proportion. Other researchers and psychologists imagined only between 1% and 3% of people would go to the end of the experiment.

[00:24:17] Then Milgram developed several theories to explain his experiments' results. The first theory was that to live in society, we must respect rules. Rules are necessary for our societies to function well. There are rules in families, at school and at work. There is the law, and internal regulations we must respect in different contexts. If nobody respects rules, we're in a situation of anarchy. Ultimately, throughout our lives we're raised, educated, to learn to respect these different rules. We respect them when we think they're fair, when we respect the authority that wrote them. In Milgram's experiment, the authority was scientific authority. You remember this experiment took place at Yale, a very prestigious and serious university, and was supervised by a team of scientists. So participants could see this authority concretely and generally respected it.

[00:25:56] What's more, when we lose our responsibility, when authority assumes all responsibility, obeying becomes more comfortable for us. We no longer need to think. We can simply obey. Stanley Milgram called this state in which an individual obeys the "agentic state": when the individual is no longer autonomous, but becomes merely an agent carrying out an authority's decisions.

[00:26:44] What are the different implications of Stanley Milgram's conclusions? Stanley Milgram used this experiment to explain the crimes of the Holocaust. You remember I told you in the first part that Stanley Milgram grew up in a Jewish family. So of course, he was deeply affected by the crimes against the Jewish community during the Second World War. With this theory, he tried to explain that the people participating in these crimes were only following orders. They conformed to the authority of the Nazi regime. Each person was simply a link in the chain, part of the group, and responsibility for all their actions belonged to the authority, the regime.

[00:27:51] But in response to these experiments and Milgram's results, many criticisms appeared. The first concerned ethics. An experiment in which participants are deceived, lied to, not told the truth, well, isn't a politically correct experiment, because there's no longer a relationship of trust between the participant and the experiment's organisers, the researchers.

[00:28:30] It was also shown that Milgram influenced the experiment's results to obtain the highest figures possible. For example, the assistant insisted strongly that the participant continue. He said, "You must continue", repeating it many times. This criticism says the experiment isn't valid and the results are distorted.

[00:29:10] But another very interesting thing is that Milgram's experiment was repeated in 2009 in France and Switzerland, this time outside a university. This time, it took place in a fake television game show, a television programme. The conditions and principle were the same, but scientific authority was replaced by television's authority, with a female presenter. What do you think the result was? Higher or lower than Milgram's experiments? Well, it was even higher: 81% of participants went to the end, to 450 volts. Eighty-one percent is enormous! This experiment was used to denounce reality television's power, to show television has too much authority over its viewers. If you want to watch a documentary about this programme, I'll put a link in the description. Have a look. It's very interesting.

[00:30:40] And you, how far do you think you would have gone? It's difficult to say when you aren't in those conditions. Generally, we think we would have stopped the experiment immediately. But when we're in those conditions, it's completely different.

[00:31:08] In conclusion, we can say rules are part of our societies. We need rules to live together. They're part of our everyday lives. But we must always keep our critical thinking. When our conscience tells us something is wrong, we must question authority. We must never trust an authority blindly.

[00:31:52] There we are, thank you, everyone, for listening to this tenth episode. Next time, we'll talk about good habits for being more productive, particularly the miracle morning. If you want to learn how to be more effective in the morning, join me next week. Thank you, everyone, and see you soon!